

## Java To Go Open Source

Java will be going open source, Sun's new vice president of Software, Rich Green, announced at the 2006 JavaOne Conference in San Francisco. "It is not a question of whether," he said, "but a question of how." As for "when", Green could only say, "as soon as possible."



## Word To Have Blogging Support

The forthcoming version of Microsoft Word will allow users to publish blog postings directly from the application. Bloggers who currently use Word to draft their posts experience trouble when they paste the text into online blog publishing tools because Word uses non-standard HTML tags.



# Enter

**VJ Sophia**  
(Sophia Chaudhry)  
Singer/VJ

Sophia has had our attention as a VJ and singer for some time now. An alumnus of the London School of Economics, she is fluent in French and Italian, and also sings in Arabic and Spanish. She sang the backing vocals for Alisha Chinai's *Made in India* and recently acted in the movie *Shaadi No. 1*.

### What does technology mean to you?

I would be understating facts if I called technology "simply amazing." It is so much more than that. The leaps and bounds we have made with technology aiding us is testimony to its usefulness.

### Which of your gadgets are you inseparable from?

I carry my Panasonic portable DVD everywhere with me and, of course, my iPod mini is my constant companion too.

### Any instance where technology has come to your rescue?

As a single working girl in a city, the cell phone is a definite advantage when I have to keep my family informed about my safety, as I discovered during the floods in Mumbai last year. It similarly must have helped reduce panic for others a little.

### What would you say are the limitations of technology?

With technology comes power but not many use it properly. Camera phones, although a breakthrough invention, can sometimes be a nuisance. The brilliance of technology is marred by its misuse.

## THE RACE IS GOING AWRY

# Do The Poor Want PCs Or Phones?

There's a race on to provide cheap PCs to the world's poor, but something seems to be going wrong. Mid-May, a group of technology leaders from developing countries—delegates at the World Congress on Information Technology (WCIT) in Austin, Texas—criticised AMD, Intel and MIT for not co-operating in their efforts to create low-cost computers. They also added that they'd prefer to see the likes of Nokia and Motorola bringing in cell phones to their countries before PCs. At WCIT, AMD, Intel and MIT all made pitches about why their low-cost computers would get the job done better than the others'.

AMD gave each WCIT attendee a PIC (Personal Internet Communicator). This Internet enabler has a no-frills version of Windows, and a thick plastic casing for protection. Intel's CEO Paul Otellini unveiled the Eduwise laptop: the chip giant believes the cheap computers should have full OSes as well as most of the cutting-edge technology found on more expensive computers. The Eduwise costs more than

AMD's PIC, but it's faster. MIT's Nicholas Negroponte made an appearance before the WCIT crowd to make his pitch for the now-famous hand-cranked \$100 laptop, pictured below.

"When I listen to the multiple presentations here, I wonder... are they talking to each other in terms of how they can collaborate," said Theogene Rudasingwa, a technology expert from Rwanda. "It occurred to me that probably they are not... We need to do a little more in seeing how we can collaborate... How can we put all these things together into some kind of sustainable effort that begins to have an impact on people in the developing world."

"We are also worried whether AMD, Intel and the MIT professor are talking to each other," said Ibrahim Kaliisa, special advisor on technology to the president of Uganda. "It can be about moral obligation here, but it

also must make business sense for these companies. Maybe that is why they are not talking to each other."

Co-operation seems unlikely given that AMD and Intel don't see their low-cost PC efforts as charity projects, but as seeding potential growth markets with their brands.

But are PCs what the developing world wants?

"I think we need to raise the first question, which is, should we have a PC-oriented view on communications," said C K Prahalad, a business professor and author at the University of Michigan. Prahalad backed the idea that there will be more growth and interest around cell phones in the coming years in developing nations. Companies, according to Prahalad, should concentrate on creating affordable service plans, as well as devices that provide PC-like tools.

Teresa Peters, a senior program officer at the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, said in reference to the cheap PCs:

"At the individual level, the people on the ground aren't clamouring for these kinds of devices." In contrast, they want cell phones, she said.

Even if it is a PC the people want, the price point is a topic of much debate—\$400, say, is too expensive, and no-one wants a barely-usable \$100 device. Will the

